aim of securing the territorial integrity of his satellite states. The Helsinki Accords, according to its own description, were motivated by the ‘political will, in the interest of peoples, to improve and intensify their relations and to contribute in Europe to peace, security, justice and cooperation as well as to rapprochement among themselves and with the other States of the world’.

Ready to play his part, Honecker spent April and May putting out cautious feelers to fix a ‘private encounter’ with US President Gerald Ford who would be present in the Finnish capital. ‘Honecker speaks highly of you, and Secretary Kissinger,’ US ambassador to Berlin, John Sherman Cooper told Ford before the Finland gathering. ‘They never mention Vietnam or economics, except trade. He said you were the biggest moral influence since Eisenhower. We should make the greatest efforts we can with them.’2 Despite flattering overtures, the unofficial response was not encouraging. In a short telex to Cooper, Secretary of State Henry Kissinger sent the President’s regrets but noted:

in giving our reply, you might also note that assuming the seating arrangement is based on the French alphabetical order, the President and the First Secretary will be sitting next to each other during the conference sessions, and they will undoubtedly have the opportunity to exchange informal greetings.3

Besides Honecker and his party, a brigade of GDR journalists accompanied the delegation to Helsinki where the Finns had prepared a stunning ceremony, complete with appropriate pomp and ceremony. The Treaty, unveiled at Finlandia House, a vast white marble building in central Helsinki, was followed closely in East Germany. In the first speech, British Prime Minister Harold Wilson described the meeting as a turning point in history: